

GARETH EVANS

FEASTING AT THE TABLE

A Study in the Book of Ephesians



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Gareth Evans

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Matthew 10:8

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1938–

Gareth Evans, born in 1938 in Merthyr Tydfil, is an itinerant pastor, teacher, and author. He studied physics, taught globally, authored devotionals, and now ministers to the hurting church through his website. Gareth, married to Anne, has three daughters, eight grand children, and fourteen great-grand children. His teachings emphasize practical faith and biblical wisdom. With a unique blend of scientific background and spiritual insight, Evans brings clarity to complex theological concepts.

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Paul's Prayer

We start our study by considering Paul's prayer in chapter 1:15-19 and make it our prayer.

Paul writes: "... making mention of you in my prayers; that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give to you a spirit of wisdom and of revelation in the knowledge of Him. I pray that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened, so that you will know what is the hope of His calling, what are the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints, and what is the surpassing greatness of His power toward us who believe." (NASB) Wow! What a prayer! Is this your desire as we begin this book? Do you want to know Him more?

Such knowledge only comes by revelation – no amount of learning, studying, etc., can bring us to this knowledge. It is possible to know everything about Him but not know Him personally. This is a prayer for intimacy with the Creator and His Son. (Consider Peter's recognition that Jesus is the Christ, and the Master's response in Matt 16:16,17 – Blessed are you, Simon, for flesh and blood did not reveal this to you, but My Father who is in Heaven) How can I set myself in a posture that God is pleased to answer this prayer?

Consider Moses. He had met God at the burning bush, seen His miracles in Egypt, culminating in the crossing of the Red Sea; followed the cloud by day and the pillar of fire by night; heard God's voice several times – yet there was a hunger to know God more. He cried, " O God, please

show me Your Glory!” In response, God declared, “I know your name so I will show you My name” - Ex 33:18,19. In Bible times, one’s name was very important. Jacob (Deceiver) was changed to Israel (Prince with God) when he met God; Saul (after mighty King Saul) was changed to Paul (little one); Peter (little stone) was changed to Cephas (rock). John Bunyan’s Pilgrim’s Progress plays much on the meaning of one’s name. It reveals one’s inner character .

God’s revelation of Himself is determined by our name (our inner man/character). So, what is your name? Is it Doubtful or Timorous, Hypocrite or Proudful, Faithful or Overcomer? The apostle John wrote that spiritual maturity (‘fatherhood’) is defined by those who have “ come to know Him who has been from the beginning ” and the only way to come there is by first being a ‘young man’ who is strong because the Word of God abides in you and you have overcome the evil one . (1 John 2:12-15). God is always willing to reveal more of Himself to the one who is an overcomer when faced with the tests of life. Note that in every letter, the glorified Jesus dictates to John in Revelation 2&3 where there is the phrase, “to him who overcomes I will...” Further, note that in John’s letter, these are not natural ages or genders. I know many young men and women who are spiritual ‘fathers/mothers’, having come to know God in a deeply personal way. Sadly, I also know many older people who are still little children (childish) when it comes to spiritual maturity.

Paul now prays for three things : 1. To him, there are three great jewels – faith, hope, and love – which he links together at least 7 times in his letters. (See how many you can find!) He has heard of the Ephesians’ faith and love, so he now prays that they might also know the hope of His calling .

Faith and hope have been greatly misunderstood by many in the church. As I study faith , without which it is impossible to please God (Heb 11:6), I see it expressed in three different ways. There is ‘saving faith’

(Eph 2:8) – the starting point beyond which too many believers never advance; there is the ‘fruit of faith’ (Gal 5:22) which gradually is produced by the Holy Spirit in the life of the believer who ‘abides’ in Christ (see Ps 1:3); there is the ‘gift of faith’ (1 Cor 12:9) granted by the Holy Spirit in certain needful circumstances. Note that all have their source in God – you cannot produce one iota of faith by your effort!

I define faith as “the word of God ‘spoken’ into the heart of a believer leading him/her into God’s will”. It is an attribute of the heart (not the mind) and is evidenced in obedience . Like love, it is guarded by the breast-plate (1 Thess 5:8), whereas hope is an attribute of the mind, represented by the helmet.

My favourite verse is Galatians 2:20, which states “I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me. ” (KJV) It was his hope (not his faith) that caused Paul to stand boldly before Felix and Agrippa – see Acts 24:15, 21, and 26:6. Hope is “an inner certainty of God’s promises being true” or “an eager expectation of that which is certain .” It is an attribute of the mind and is evidenced in confidence.

See Heb 10:35.

Such ‘confidence’ is lacking in so many believers today , and our prayers should be, like Paul’s, that we might know the hope of our calling.

2. He secondly prays that they might know the riches of glory of His inheritance in the saints.

Glory is the manifest presence of God – all that He is willing to reveal of Himself among His people. God wants to make His presence known in the life of a believer, in the church, and the community around the church. When did you last experience the glory of His presence? That should be the lot of every believer! “ Christ in us – the hope of glory”. Col 1:27. I have

been blessed several times by the Lord, making His presence known so that I, with others, have had to declare “ Surely, the Lord is in this place !” This was not just our belief, but an experience as real as a physical presence. That is what the apostle is praying for us.

3. Thirdly, that they might know the surpassing greatness of His power to us who believe . That is what happened on the day of Pentecost and is the power (*dunamis*) promised to all believers to make them effective as His witnesses. (Acts 1:8; 2:39) This is not the power granted to enable us to ‘become children of God’ (*exousia*) (John 1:12), but a greater power to enable us to be His witnesses. How feeble is our effort when we neglect this deep work of the Holy Spirit! The disciples had received the Spirit as life when Jesus breathed upon them in the upper room, the day after His resurrection (John 20:23), but they had to wait in Jerusalem seven more weeks until they received the power from on high to enable them to do the work they were sent to do.

Similarly, Jesus had the Holy Spirit in Him from conception, but needed the anointing of the Spirit upon Him at baptism before He could do the work He was sent to do. After the dove had descended upon Him, He stood in the synagogue in Nazareth, read from the prophet Isaiah about the anointing of God, and then declared, “This day , this scripture has been fulfilled.” (Luke 4:21) If He needed such an anointing, how much more do we?

Tozer said that “ dispensationalism (which includes the belief that miracles and the baptism with the Holy Ghost are not for today) has done more damage to the church than liberalism, for the latter has robbed the church of its message, but the former has robbed the church of its power.”

The prayer of Paul is continued in chapter 3:14-19. He had been side-tracked by the thrill of all that Jesus had meant to him in answer to his prayers for Himself, as we shall see in the next chapter.

Now, he adds to his prayers for us: "... that He would grant you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with power through His Spirit in the inner man so that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith; and that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may be able to comprehend with all the saints what is the breadth and length and height and depth and to know the love of Christ which surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled up to all the fullness of God."

Again, 'comprehend' like 'know' is an experiential word, not simply a belief.

Does this not make you hunger and thirst after His righteousness?

"O Lord, we hunger for You to make Your presence known in our lives. May our names be such that you are pleased to reveal more of your Name to us. You promised to disclose Yourself to those who love You (John 14:21), and we believe your promises are true. We love you, Lord!"

In Him

The second item we shall ‘take off the table’ is the phrase “In Him”, found throughout chapters 2 and 3. Let us first consider the Old Testament story of Noah’s ark (Gen 7). God sees the evil in the world and is determined to destroy all mankind except for one man who has found grace in His sight. Noah is instructed to build a large boat into which God will place all those whom He will deliver from the destruction of a great flood. Noah is obedient to obey this command, even though he had no comprehension of a flood and no support from either his family or his neighbours.

He must have seemed a strange sight to them all! After many years of work, the day comes when the vessel is completed, and God is ready to carry out His judgment. Noah, his wife, together with their sons and their wives, are instructed to enter into the ark, taking with them couples of every animal in their known world. Then, God closes the door, and the rains begin to fall.

Consider this: Noah’s salvation was dependent on his entering the ark. There was no deliverance if he stayed outside, admiring his work!

Using this story as a metaphor, neither is there salvation for any of mankind unless they enter into God’s provision of a way of escape – the man Christ Jesus. There comes a time when we must enter into Him by faith – saving faith – for judgment will surely come on all those who try to find another way to appease God. Jesus said, “ I am the way... there is no way to the Father except through me. ” (John 14:6) Now, when God looks

upon us, He sees us “in His Son”. We can greatly rejoice that He does not consider our sinful nature anymore , for ‘ the Son gets in His eyes’. Our guilt and shame have been wrapped up in Him. The Son of Man shed His precious life’s blood to cover our sins to produce the pearl of greatest price (Matt 13:46). It cost us nothing; it cost Him everything.

I understand that, in Bible days, pearls were very rare, and the finest would be used as a major adornment on the Roman emperor. So it is that the ‘pearl of greatest price’ is now being polished by the Holy Spirit to become an adornment for the King of kings when He returns to take His bride, His purchased possession to Himself.

Thus it is that in Ephesians 1 & 2 the apostle Paul tells us some of the great privileges we have simply because we are “in Him”. Ephesians 1:3 highlights that God has blessed us with every spiritual blessing in heavenly places in Him. Such blessings are ‘in heavenly places’, but sadly, many of us live outside that realm! They are ours only as we abide in Him. It is possible to be “in Christ” but not abiding in Him. So many of us move back and forth between living a life “in Christ” and living “in the world”. On several occasions, Jesus addressed his followers with these words, “If you abide in me...” This is like having a vast sum deposited in our bank but we never take advantage of it, living as a pauper!

Let us consider some of these blessings: Ephesians 1:4: In Him we have been chosen so that we might be holy and blameless before Him.

This gives us access to God. We are not chosen because of any merits of our own, but our choosing is ‘in Him’. There is no salvation outside of Him. His purpose in having a people “in Christ” is that we might be a people set apart, different to the world around us and a witness to them.

Ephesians 1:5: In love, we have been predestined to become ‘sons’ – joint heirs with Jesus of the riches of the Father. He wants to make us like Himself so that we might be ‘to the praise of His glory.’ In Jewish culture,

there was quite a process to adopt a son, but having been adopted, that son had all the rights and privileges of the natural son. Even more so! The father could always disown his natural son, even have him put to death, but he could never disown or abandon the son he had adopted!

I love that word! I rejoice that, though a sinner, I am saved by grace; I am privileged to be His servant, glad to be in His service; but most of all blessings, I am thrilled to be His son with access to my Father! He is worthy of our lives.

Is what you live for worth Christ dying for? Secular humanism declares that man exists for the benefit of man; Christian humanism declares that God exists for the benefit of man; true Christianity declares that man exists for the benefit of God! (1 Cor 8:6) – that we might be ‘to the praise of His glory!’

“May the Lamb that was slain receive the reward of His suffering” – Moravian motto.

Ephesians 1:6: He has bestowed grace upon us – “in Him”, the beloved. GRACE - God’s Riches At Christ’s Expense!

Ephesians 1:7: In Him we have redemption – have been purchased back from slavery; forgiveness is complete and free. This is due to His grace lavished upon us.

Ephesians 1:9-10: The mystery – only known by revelation – that at the end of all administrations (dispensations), God will bring together all things in Christ – both in the heavens and on earth. All creation, angels and fallen angels, the redeemed and the non-redeemed, will be subject to Him.

Natural man cannot receive such a revelation – it is foolishness to him. (1 Cor 2:14) Ephesians 1:11: We have received an inheritance in Him. Not earned or as a reward! Ours simply because we are ‘in Him’ and God is pleased to bless us. Inheritance is a right resulting from a relationship. In this case, the right belongs to the children of God because their identifica-

tion as children of God by faith in the eternal Son of God has been established and is in the heavenly records! The apostle said of us: “Men and women cannot imagine or even dream of all the things which God has prepared for those who love Him!” (Tozer). This is all done so that we might respond to ‘the praise of His glory.’ Ephesians 1:13: In Him we have been ‘sealed’ with the Holy Spirit of Promise. I shall expand on this in Chapter 3.

Let me repeat: These riches are all ours “in Christ” – but we must appropriate them for ourselves!

These are theological truths, but, sadly, for many believers, they are not experiential truths. It is like having great riches in the bank but living like paupers because we do not draw on our wealth.

Jesus said that “if we abide in Him...” showing that it is very possible not to be ‘abiding’ – enjoying the riches available to us.

Paul is so carried away with this thought that he cries out his wonderful prayer for us that we might know (experience) these riches now. This begins another anthem of praise waxing lyrical about the exalted glories of Jesus (v20-23) and our position in Him.

Identification with Christ (being ‘in Him’) is a major emphasis of Paul’s. We are reckoned to have died ‘in Him’ and have risen ‘in Him’ (Rom 6:11). That is accounted to us so that the Father now only considers us ‘in Him’. He does not see our sin, for the SON has got in His eyes!! We were identified with Adam as our “federal head” and became sinners through his sin of disobedience.

However, the second ‘Adam’ came to be the federal head of a new race of people – those He has redeemed through His shed blood and resurrection. (See Romans 5). This concept of identification is common to Jewish thought, contrary to our independence.

Chapter 1:20-23: God has exalted Jesus far above all principalities and powers – these are names of the recognised angelic beings, both good and

evil. He is above them all and cannot be overcome by them. They were conquered on the cross 2000 years ago, when He made an open show of them.

Colossians 2:15.

Chapter 2:1-6: If I abide in Him , I am also seated above the principalities and powers. They cannot hurt me unless I allow my guard to slip, my shield to fall and the arrows of the evil one penetrate my feeble defense. We were dead as we walked according to the things of this world. But God, rich in mercy and love, has raised us up and seated us in heavenly places in Christ Jesus! Now!

Sealed and Seated

We must reconsider the main emphases of Paul's teaching in the previous studies. From chapter 1-2:9, we have three long, lyrical outpourings showing the apostle's enthusiasm for his subject. Other than the interposed prayer, his emphasis is on the riches of our blessings "in Christ". Two major blessings are our being 'sealed in Him' (1:13) and our being 'seated in Him' (2:6). We shall now consider these in more detail. They need to be 'reckoned to us' and appropriated by us, i.e. we must actively pursue them.

Sealed in Him with the Holy Spirit of Promise.

(1:13) "... in whom, having believed, you were sealed in Him with the Holy Spirit of promise."

This is what the disciples experienced on the Day of Pentecost having been instructed by Jesus to 'wait in Jerusalem for what the Father had promised' (Acts 1:4). This promise can be found in Isaiah 44:3 ("I will pour water on him that is thirsty, and floods upon the dry ground: I will pour My Spirit upon thy seed and My blessing upon thy offspring") ; Ezekiel 36:26,27 ("A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put in you....") ; Joel 2:28 ("I will pour My Spirit upon all flesh; and your sons and daughters will prophesy..."), and was added to by Jesus in John 7:39.

Peter understands this promise for he quotes from Joel in his great sermon on the Day of Pentecost, adding that “Jesus, having received from the Father the promise of the Holy Spirit, has poured forth this which you both see and hear.” (Acts 2:33) The disciples had been ‘born again’ (received new life) when Jesus breathed upon them on the Sunday following His resurrection (John 20:22 – *enthusao* – I breathe into). They were there given power (*exousia*) to become the sons of God (John 1:12). On the day of Pentecost they would receive power (*dunamis*) to be His witnesses (Acts 1:8). Too many believers today are operating in *exousia* power and not the *dunamis* power which alone can enable us to be the overcomers we are called to be. *Dunamis* is the Greek word from which we get dynamite!

When Paul came to Ephesus on his last missionary journey, he asked the local disciples if they had received the Holy Spirit when they believed. They had repented, become believers, but had not been ‘sealed’. After Paul laid his hands on them, they received the same experience as the disciples did in Jerusalem on the Day of Pentecost. (Acts 19:1-7).

To the early church, the sealing of the Spirit (‘baptism with the Holy Spirit’ – Acts 1:5) was the normal expectation and experience of the believers. To those who had drifted from this teaching, Paul would write letters such as his thesis to the Romans – see chapter 7 for the conflict that arises when operating only in *exousia* power, and contrast it with chapter 8 onward, where he constantly talks about the ministry of the Holy Spirit within us.

How, then, does one come to this realisation or experience this ‘sealing’? One must believe that such a sealing is for us - there must be a wanting and longing to be filled with the Spirit. The early disciples were told to ‘tarry’ in Jerusalem. This is not just waiting patiently, but was a time spent in eager expectation, prayer, and worship. See Luke 11:9-13 – all

three verbs are continuous present – keep on seeking; keep on asking... and He will give the Holy Spirit.

We are called to come ‘with clean hands and a pure heart’ if we would enter His presence. Moses wanted to know the glory of God, so he was instructed to prepare himself before presenting himself to the Lord. (See Exodus 34:2).

Ephesians 5:15-21 tells us that the Spirit-filled life is evidenced by (a) a worshipping attitude (v19); (b) a thankful attitude (v20); (c) a servant attitude (v21). Maybe we should practice these attitudes as a precursor to receiving that fullness.

O Comforter, gentle and tender; O holy and heavenly dove, I’m yielding my heart in surrender, I’m waiting Thy fullness to prove Anoint me with gladness and healing, baptize me with power from on high, O come with Thy fullness and sealing while low at Thy footstool I bow. A B Simpson “When a man is filled with the Spirit, he knows it!” A W Tozer Seated us with Him (the Father) in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus. (2:6) To be ‘seated’ with the Father means to have ceased from our efforts to please Him. He has accepted us in Christ and we are now called to enter into “His rest” (Hebrews 4:9). We may miss this rest by disobedience to the call of faith – His promptings within us (Heb 4:11). “The one who entered His rest has himself also rested from his works, as God did from His” (Heb 4:10).

A good picture is given to us by the wanderings of the Children of Israel in the wilderness. They had been delivered from Egypt with all its bondage and task masters and were called to enter into Canaan, the land of (God’s) promises. Because of their unbelief, they had to wander for 40 years in the wilderness before finally entering the land under Joshua.

Egypt represents our life without Christ – the ‘natural man’. The wilderness represents the ‘carnal man’ – believing but not resting in ‘heav-

only places' in Christ. He has crossed the Red Sea where the former taskmasters were cut off from him – I see this as a work of water baptism (see Col 2:11, 12), but has not yet entered into God's purposes for him. Canaan represents the promises of God, being sealed in the Holy Spirit, and being seated in heavenly places. It is the place of giants and overcoming (by His Spirit, not our efforts!), of 'milk and honey' and feasting with Him. It does NOT represent heaven or life after death – but should be the experience of all believers NOW.

I exchange my struggles for His victories; my weakness for His strength; my wishes for His will; my understanding for His faith; my burden for His yoke.

"I have been crucified with Christ; and it is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me; and the life I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me." (Gal 2:20) We need to understand that this is God's will for you and me . We need to "reckon ourselves" dead to sin (Rom 6:11) and alive to God. We need to cultivate "abiding in Christ" in heavenly places by regular devotions and worship. Only as we abide in Him there, can we overcome (by His power) all the forces of darkness which are "beneath His feet" (Eph 1:21 , 22). Claim your place in heavenly realms now.

Though being "seated in Christ" is a theological truth, too many believers are not abiding there.

Jesus said, "If you abide in Me..." implying that it is very possible to not be doing so. Should you visit my home, you might truly say, "I am seated in Gareth's home", unless you receive my invitation to stay with me, you could not say "I am abiding in Gareth's home"! Those who do 'abide' share my table and the comforts and fellowship that it affords.

To those who abide in Christ, Jesus has promised a maturing fruit of the Spirit: power in prayer and a closeness of fellowship. (John 15:7-11) I

would suggest that this is also the meaning of Isaiah 40:31, where the Hebrew word qavah (translated as ‘wait’ in the KJV) has the root meaning of being “bound together”. Are you tightly bound together with the Lord; i.e., abiding in Him? Only those who are such can “ gain new strength. They will mount up with wings like eagles. They will run and not grow weary; they will walk and not grow faint.”

A Body and a Building

God has purposed that all things will be ‘summed up’ in Christ (Ephesians 1:10); that Jews and Gentiles are ‘made alive together’ in Him (2:5); that the division between them is ‘broken down’ and they are ‘made one’ (2:14); they are ‘fellow members’ (3:6) of the ‘body’. To Paul, there is no such thing as an independent believer – neither independent of God, nor independent of other believers.

Paul introduces us to two concepts to explain his understanding of the church – the ‘eklesia’ (called-out ones) of Jesus Christ: The ‘body’ (Eph 1:23) and the ‘building’ (Eph 2:22).

The Body of Christ

The church is to be thought of as a unity of people, both Jews and Gentiles.

This is NOT uniformity nor ecumenicism (Promotion of cooperation and unity among Christians).

The body’s characteristic is that Jesus is its head and it is His fullness (1:23). It exists to do the will of its head and master. Paul might have been aware of the prayer of Jesus recorded for us in John 17 – “that they may be One as You (the Father) and I (the Son) are one”. The last prayer of Jesus for all who would come to believe Him, is that we may be ONE. Further, that we might be ‘one’ as He and the Father are ‘one’. There is no tension here – no conflict of differing goals, ideas, etc., but a unity molded in love.

The outcome of such unity will be that “the world will know that You sent Me and loved them, even as You loved Me” (John 17:23).

The body is a good example of many differing parts functioning as ‘one’. In a healthy body, all parts coordinate well even though some may be ‘in opposition’ to one another. E.g. for progress, one leg pushes backward as the other reaches forward! The foot cannot say to the hand ‘I have no need of you’ nor can the ear say to the eye ‘I have no need of you’. (1 Cor 12:15). Might one say, “the Baptist cannot say to the Pentecostal ‘I have no need of you’; nor vice versa. The evangelist cannot say to the teacher ‘I have no need of you,’ etc. ?” Where there are parts of the body which do not do what they are designed to do, the body is sick or dysfunctional.

Paul teaches much about the body and its ministry in three places: Romans 12, 1 Corinthians 12, and here in Ephesians. It is striking that these are the same three references where he writes concerning the operation of the Holy Spirit in gifting individuals for service. Some are gifted to ‘equip the saints’ (4:12) while others are gifted to minister to a lost world with the hands and heart of Jesus. None is gifted for their own, individual enjoyment. How sad it is when we envy others’ giftings and ministry and fail to exercise/those which the Holy Spirit has given to us! Every one of us has been given a Holy Spirit gift for ministering to the common good (1 Cor 12:7). Are you using yours? Do not know what it is? Ask your pastor or some godly people in your fellowship – you might be surprised what they can see that you do not see!

“The whole body, being fitted and held together by what each joint supplies, according to the proper working of each part, causes the growth of the body for the building up of itself in love.”

Eph 4:16).

Consider the unity that exists between the Father and the Son.

How do I contribute my part of the functioning body – “so that the world may believe”? (John 17:21) Whenever I am asked semi-seriously, “So, what part of the Body are you?” I usually reply, with an appropriate grin, “Why, I’m a big toe!” I then add in explanation, “I often find myself in the dark, smelly places of the lives of those I am counselling. However, as a teacher/encourager, I count it my responsibility, and privilege, to bring balance to the body.”

The building – a holy temple – a dwelling place of God

Paul joins Peter in presenting the church as a building, made of living stones (1 Pet 2:5). It is built on the foundation of both the apostles and prophets (new covenant and old covenant) and is being ‘built together’ to be a dwelling place for God, the Holy Spirit. Jesus is the ‘chief cornerstone’ (Eph 2:20) that establishes the lines. As in the body, all the parts are bound together in unity and each have a particular function. One does not use door jambs for rafters, nor glass windows for flooring!

How ridiculous such a building would be! Paul calls himself a wise master builder who wishes to lay a foundation upon which others can build carefully (1 Cor 3:10).

We are all to be builders, just as we are also the building. “Do you not know that you are a temple of God and that the Spirit of God dwells in you?”

As we consider these two metaphors for the church, we must come to the conclusion that the church is meant to be a functioning entity, in which each member has a particular and important role to play. Jesus said that He would build His church and the gates of Hell would not prevail against it (Matt 16:18). Such a church is bonded together in love and minis-

tering in the power of an indwelling Holy Spirit. Naturally, Satan will do his utmost to divide this church, sadly with the aid of many of its members!

If we would know ‘the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints’ or ‘the exceeding greatness of His power to us who believe’ (1:18 , 19), it is incumbent upon us that we fulfill our roles as members of the body and as a building fitly framed together as a habitation of the Holy Spirit.

So, what part of the Body are you? Are you functioning in your Holy Spirit giftings, or are you weak because you are envious of another’s giftings?

I was once the guest speaker at a Full Gospel Business Men’s dinner. I arrived early at the hotel and was warmly greeted by two men. A short time later, another brother joined us, but it was soon obvious that he wasn’t in a good place emotionally. As I listened to the conversation that followed, I gathered that his wife was not in harmony with him concerning his coming out that evening.

“Let’s pray together , ” suggested one of my new friends, so in typical FGBM fashion, we joined arms in the hotel lobby and they began to pray for the newcomer. After we finished, I said to him, “I don’t know if this means anything to you, but as we prayed, I saw a house in a rainstorm. The rain was beating down into the house.” He fell to the floor weeping. Finally, getting to his feet, he said, “Brothers, I must go home!” then turning to me, said “Thank you! On my way here this evening, I was complaining to the Lord about my wife when He said, “You are a leaky roof! When you get yourself in order, I will do something about your wife!” God had given me a word of knowledge for that brother. (1 Cor 12:9) John Donne, a sixteenth-century Anglican priest, wrote: No man is an island, entire of itself; every man is a piece of the continent, a part of the main. If a clod be washed away by the sea, Europe is the less, as well as if a promontory were, as well as

if a man or of thy friend's or thine own were: any man's death diminishes me, because I am involved in mankind, and therefore never send to know for whom the bell tolls; it tolls for thee. These sentiments should be true of all believers recognizing themselves as members of one body, built together as one building, a habitation of the Holy Spirit.

The church does not exist for man's blessing but for the glory of God – we are created 'for good works' (Ephesians 2:10). As we function together as a living body, as a building indwelt by the Holy Spirit, the Lord will do His work in calling men and women to Himself, counteracting the humanistic philosophies of this world's systems and bringing glory to Himself. In the words of the old Moravian missionaries, "May the Lamb that was slain receive the reward of His suffering".

A Covenant People

Ephesians 2:11-22

Paul writes a lot about ‘us’ and ‘you’. He is referring to the Jews (us) and the Gentiles (you).

He knew what a privilege it was to be a Jew. They were the chosen people of God, called out from the world to occupy a land God had chosen for them. They were recipients of God’s love and faithfulness and had a history full of His deliverance and blessing. They had the Law by which they alone could find righteousness. They had a priesthood and sacrifices by which they could approach a holy God. And they were the people from whom the Messiah would come that would rule the world – and Paul knew who that was!

The Jews had a very low opinion of the Gentiles – ‘dogs’ they were called (note the words of Jesus in Matt 15:26!).

However, Paul has been the recipient of a ‘mystery’ – that he is to be the apostle to the Gentiles (3:1-7).

See how he describes ‘you’ – Gentiles.

2: 1 dead in trespasses and sins – as we also were, children of wrath (v3)
2:11 ‘uncircumcision’. This means they were not in covenant relationship with God.

2:12 separate from God; excluded from the commonwealth of Israel; strangers to the covenants of promise, having no hope and without God in

the world. What a sad situation!

But note that he does not write about this in terms of their being sinners needing forgiveness, but rather, as aliens needing to be ‘brought near’. His thoughts do not center around salvation but on relationship and reconciliation.

Pv13: “ But now ...” Brought near, made one with the Jew.

2:18 having access to the Father 2:19 no longer strangers and aliens; fellow citizens with the saints; of God’s household.

2:20 built upon the same foundation of apostles and prophets.

Paul continues this theme into Chapter 3: 3:6: ‘You have become fellow heirs and fellow members of the ‘body’; fellow partakers of the promise in Christ Jesus.

3:8 recipients of unfathomable riches in Christ.

We have become a covenant people. I want in this chapter to speak about COVENANT.

The Jews understood covenant. They were well taught that God had made a covenant with Abraham, their ‘father’ , and repeated it to Moses in the establishment of the Law . “I will be your God and you will be My people” (Ex 6:7).

What is a covenant ? It is an agreement between two parties. In OT times, God was the party that dictated the covenant terms. He called Abram from Ur (Babylonia) and promised him a great heritage and a land (Gen 12). God repeated these promises several times in Genesis. In Gen 17, it is to be through Isaac (the son of Sarah) that the covenant will continue, not through Ishmael (the son of the bond woman). In Gen 26, the covenant promise is repeated to Isaac; in Gen 28, it is repeated to Jacob after his vision of a ladder reaching into heaven.

It seemed that the promise was in vain after Jacob immigrated to Egypt at a time of great famine.

His descendants gradually became slaves in that land after being out of the “Promised Land” for 400 years. Then Moses is raised to deliver them.

Ex 2:24: God ‘remembered’ His covenant with Abraham, Isaac , and Jacob. Ex 3:6: God declared (from a ‘burning’ bush) “I am the God of Abraham, Isaac , and Jacob”. Ex 3:15: “ Tell the people, the Lord God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob has sent you”.

Ex 6:2-4: God declares Himself to Moses as Jehovah (Lord) – a name NOT known before by Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, who only knew Him as El Shaddai – Almighty God (impersonal).

Ex 19:5: A new promise is made to the Children of Israel, now out of Egypt. “If you keep My covenant, you shall be a peculiar treasure unto Me above all other peoples.”

Then in Ex 20 the “terms” of the (old) covenant are laid out – the 10 commandments (followed by various civil laws). These were established to teach the high demands of the life God required if His people would be accepted by Him as ‘righteous’. All history attests to the fact that they were unable (and unwilling) to meet their side of the covenant agreement.

The following chapters outline the ceremonies and their laws, by which man could “draw near” to God. The highlight of those ceremonies was on the “Day of Atonement” (Yom Kippur) when the High Priest would take the blood of a (perfect) lamb and sprinkle it upon the ‘mercy seat’ in the Holy of Holies in the tabernacle. If the High Priest returned safely to his people, it was a sign that God had accepted the shed blood as a covering for their sins for another year, and the people would greatly celebrate! That was the OLD COVENANT , in which we Gentiles had no part (see above).

What is the NEW COVENANT into which we have entered? What are its benefits, and what are its terms (requirements)? Where/when did you agree to the terms?

A New Covenant was established by Jesus the night before He died. (John 13-17). He invited His disciples to share the Feast of Passover with Him. That annual feast was to celebrate the time when God had brought His people out of the bondage of Egypt by ‘passing over’ every house where the blood of a lamb had been placed upon the doorpost. (Ex 12). He had a room prepared and sent Peter and John to check that everything was ready (Luke 22). I can only imagine what each one was thinking as they entered that room.

Surely Peter must have been thinking, “Wow, what a week this has been! The crowds gathered to greet us as we came, throwing their clothes down on the street and waving palm branches! I wonder if this is the time when Jesus will reveal Himself as Messiah!” James and John, “Sons of Thunder ,” must have been more impressed as they watched Him cast the money changers out of the temple.

Surely, they must have thought, “He is about to reveal Himself as the Messiah!”

Similar thoughts must have crossed each of the disciple’s minds as they entered that room, but Jesus knew something that they did not know – tomorrow He would die!

If I knew I had only a short time to live, I would prioritise my actions. I would want to make sure that my wife and daughters knew how much I loved them. I would want to make sure I was leaving no work undone that I should have done, no debts unpaid, no promises unfulfilled.

I would not spend my time as I often do, watching sport on TV or reading a novel - I would want to deal with priorities.

This was to be a night when He would deal with PRIORITIES !

He made many wonderful promises! He promised them (and us) a place in heaven and that He will come again (John 14:3); power to do ‘greater works’ (14:12) ; the Comforter (14:16); peace, unlike the world’s

peace (14:27); fruit (15:4); fullness of joy (15:11); guidance (16:13); answered prayer (16:24). I believe He meant to fulfill these promises as I have experienced His faithfulness in so many of them. This is His side of the Covenant.

He asked of them (and us) three things: to serve one another (as He demonstrated by washing their feet, 13:14); to love one another (a commandment, 13:34); to obey His word (14:15). This is our side of the Covenant.

He has promised peace, power, the Holy Spirit, etc., if we will serve one another, love one another, and obey His word. This is the New Covenant.

At the end of supper, He took the bread and said, "This is My body for you – take and eat". Then He took the cup, saying, "This is the cup of the new covenant in My blood. Drink it." Every time you and I take the bread and cup, we are declaring our agreement to the covenant. In other words, we are saying, "I will serve Your people, I will love Your people, and I will obey Your word!"

What then are the 'laws' of this new covenant? They are written upon our hearts (Jer 31:33), and we become aware of them by the teaching and convicting word of the Holy Spirit, who alone gives us the power to live according to them. They are contained in 'the Sermon on the Mount' and other teachings of Jesus, expanded by the teachings of the epistles. They can never earn us salvation, but they are the expectation God has of every one of His children.

In acknowledgment that they were in a covenant relationship, all male Jews were circumcised – lit: 'a cutting away' of the flesh. If circumcision was the symbol or token of a covenant relationship with God, what is the 'symbol' by which we also enter a covenant relationship? See Colossians 2:11-15, recognising the very close relationship between these two books. Baptism is the act by which our hearts are circumcised – a 'cutting away' of

the flesh of the old nature. Without circumcision, the Jew could not inherit the promises of God. He could live according to the Law, even live as a 'stranger' in the land, but could not enjoy the riches of his inheritance.

In Col 2:14 we read that He has cancelled the 'certificate of death, consisting of decrees against us, which was hostile to us'. This aligns with Eph 2:15 where we read of the 'enmity, which is the Law of commandments contained in ordinances'. To us, the Law was a decree of death, for we are unable to meet its awful requirements – but Jesus has cancelled that debt.

We are now being built on the double foundation of the prophets (OT) and apostles (NT). Jehovah has become our God – we have been brought nigh because of the shed blood of the perfect lamb, Jesus – blood that covers our sin, not for a year but for all eternity!

We have become a new people, people of a New Covenant, the terms of which were given at the last Supper, the Laws of which are written upon our hearts, and the commitment to such is expressed every time we take the communion elements.

Whenever I take the bread – “His body, broken for us” - I look around me and say, “Thank you, Father, that I am a part of this body, both local and global.” Whenever I take the cup, I say, “Lord, I will serve your people, I will love your people, I will obey your Word.”

I am very aware that should I take the elements 'unworthily', i.e. I am not serving or loving His people, not obeying His word, I risk bringing judgment and sickness upon myself. (1 Cor 11:27-30).

The Privilege of Ministry

Ephesians Chapter 3:1-13

A different perspective: Paul is in prison in Rome but he recognises himself foremost, as a prisoner of Jesus Christ. Here we see again the dual nature of the believer – in this world but not of it. One's perspective can make all the difference!

Note that v2-13 are another parenthesis in Paul's teaching. "For this reason..." is repeated when he gets 'back on track' with his prayer in v14. This parenthesis is triggered by his consideration of his being 'a prisoner of Christ Jesus'. He revels in it!

He refers again to the great 'mystery' he has received by revelation from God. The Gentiles also are to receive blessings from God! That is radically different to current thought among the Jews who considered all Gentiles as "dogs" not worthy of God's attention. As Peter became the apostle to the Jews, Paul has become the apostle to the Gentiles.

Paul has received stewardship of God's grace to Gentile people. This involves a new revelation : (v3). It is not something he has discovered – but something God has revealed. It was not thought out, developed, argued through – but revealed. God has taken the initiative in choosing Paul for this great work.

Paul has received a ' grace-gift' : (v7), this was a gift to preach. Paul teaches elsewhere that there are many 'grace - gifts' (charismata) by which

we all can be ministers for Christ Jesus. Indeed, we have all been given ‘grace - gifts’ for the building up of the church (see again 1 Cor 12:11).

Paul has received a ministry : (v7), he considered this to be an awesome privilege, as all Christian service is. It has the greatest dignity and should never be despised. For this work he has received power (dunamis) – the same power that came upon the disciples at Pentecost – a mighty baptism with the Holy Spirit. He knew how impossible this work would be without that power. How sad it is to see the weakness of the church when (good) men try to do God’s work without the enabling of His Spirit with power! If Jesus needed the fullness of the Spirit to come upon him at His baptism, before He began His ministry, how much more so do we.

Paul will glory in his suffering for this great cause: (v13), he did not expect his service to be an easy one. To suffer for Christ is not a penalty; it is our glory for it is to share in the sufferings of Christ himself and an opportunity to demonstrate our loyalty to him.

The privilege of ministry : The angels in heaven did not understand this - (v10). The mystery has been revealed and God’s wisdom is now being made known to all creation through the church .

So, Paul has a double privilege – a) he has received this revelation, b) he can proclaim this message, i.e. he has received so that he might proclaim. Such an awesome privilege does not make him proud – rather, it makes him humble (v8). He realizes that his greatness does not lie in himself but in his message. True ministry (e.g. preaching) will never cause one to glory in the preacher but in the Christ who is preached.

The plan and wisdom of God : Gentiles and Jews are fellow heirs of the riches of God. They are fellow partakers of His promise in Christ (v6). This is not an afterthought of God – it was His intention from the beginning – a mystery now revealed to Paul and to all the angelic beings (rulers and au-

thorities in heavenly places). What is the ‘promise’ of the Father? – see again Chapter 3.

We together with Paul, can have boldness and access to God through faith. But like all riches that are ours in Christ, they must be appropriated – taken in. What ‘riches’ have you appropriated for yourself?

We have all been given grace-gifts (charismata) to build up the church but they are of the Spirit’s choosing, not ours. One should be very careful not to step into a ministry that God has not called you to, nor equipped you for.

A personal story

I was a highly-paid schoolteacher in 1979 when I was invited to become a pastor by my denomination’s District Superintendent. I said that would be a great privilege but I would want to know for certain that God was calling me. “What are you looking for – a flash of light from Heaven?” he asked. “Yes!” I replied. “All I’d look for is the witness of the brethren,” he said. I then added that I could not afford to go to seminary, as we had struggled financially for many years before taking on my present teaching position, just two years earlier. To my surprise, he then said that he would not want me to go to seminary but would welcome me as I was! He saw something in me that I was not aware of! A few weeks later, my pastor was leaving the pulpit to go into an itinerant singing ministry. As the only elder with some preaching experience, I spoke at his farewell, following which two men came to me, both retired pastors who knew nothing of my conversation with the District Superintendent, saying, “Brother, you shouldn’t be teaching!

You should be in the ministry!” – the “witness of the brethren”. The next several months, I wrestled with God, afraid to tell my wife of the growing witness within me. Six months later, I told Anne.

To her surprise and contrary to all her feelings about life as a pastor's wife, my godly wife released me with the words, "If God is calling you, and you'd better obey!" Read my book *Stepping Stones* to see something of the amazing journey the Lord has led me on since that day.

I believe our seminaries have done a disservice to the church when they release men/women into the pastoral ministry simply because they graduate top of their class. Going to seminary, passing exams with good marks does not make one a pastor. Such are given to the church by the Lord Himself. Ephesians 4:11 declares, "He gave some as apostles, some as prophets and some as evangelists and some as pastors and teachers". They are Christ's gift to His precious bride, the church. One should be very careful before assuming a position the Lord may not have called you to.

V 14 : "For this reason..." – Paul continues his prayer of chapter 1: 15-20 and as he had intended at 3:1. He wants them to receive what is theirs by 'right' through the atoning work of the cross – and according to God's riches in glory (v16).

- ✓ 'power through His Spirit in the inner man' .
- ✓ Christ dwelling in our hearts by faith.
- ✓ Being rooted and grounded in love.
- ✓ Comprehension of God's vast love for us .
- ✓ Fullness of God.

Wow! Now read again Paul's prayer in 1:15 -20 and on to 3:14-19. What is your response?

No wonder Paul is again forced to worship!

Note also that Paul 'bows his knees' whereas the normal posture for prayer to a Jew is standing – this emphasizes Paul's earnestness in prayer.

The Christian Walk

I trust we have learned to “sit” in Christ as in chapter 3. (Eph 2:6) – knowing what it is that has thrilled Paul, causing him to pray such a wonderful prayer for us. Now he exhorts us to walk.

We are to “walk in a manner worthy of our calling”. (4:1) We are to “walk no longer as the Gentiles in the futility of our mind.” (4:17) We are to “walk in love, just as Christ also loved you.” (5:2) We are to “walk as children of light.” (5:8) We are to “walk as wise men not as unwise.” (5:15) “I’m not interested in your talk - show me your walk!” Your walk is determined by the ground on which you stand; in this world (system) or in ‘heavenly places’?

Rise with thy risen Lord, ascend with Christ above, and in the heavens walk with Him, Whom seeing not, you love.

Walk as a heavenly race, Princes of royal blood; walk as the children of the light, the sons and heirs of God. A B Simpson 4:1: WALK in a manner worthy of your calling : with humility, gentleness, patience, tolerance – in love. Elsewhere these may be seen among the fruit of the Spirit (Galatians 5:22, 23). They take time to grow! A fruit tree does not produce its fruit by striving; as it takes in the sunshine and the rain, feeds upon the nourishment of the ground, it brings forth its fruit. Similarly, we cannot produce the fruit of the Spirit by our own efforts. We are to be “like a tree planted by rivers of water that brings forth fruit in its season.” Ps 1:3).

When we arrived in Canada, we bought an old house where there were four fruit trees in the garden.

They had been left alone and bore no fruit so I decided to prune them. My friends thought I had cut away too much and that the trees would now die. Imagine our delight the following spring when they bore a vast quantity of luscious fruit, apples, plums and cherries!

One evening, Anne and I were sitting on our garden chairs when I heard a very strange sound – a groaning followed by an ‘ahhh’ of relief. I could not determine the source of the sound until I noticed one of the branches on the apple tree swelling with a sound of pain before it suddenly burst, and a beautiful apple appeared! Then another branch began to swell with the same result.

Anne and I were amazed as we watched cherries, plums, and apples suddenly appear after straining and groaning.

Now I hope you realise that I am making this story up! Fruit doesn’t grow that way. The story is very foolish – just like believers who think they can produce the Fruit of the Spirit by their effort!

No amount of striving will produce joy or peace or gentleness, etc., in your life – only abiding in Him can produce such fruit.

In passing: as we consider those fruits, we see that they grow more ‘exotic’ (rare) as we read along.

Further, the first three (love, joy, peace) are ‘inward’; the second three (longsuffering, gentleness, goodness) relate mostly to my response to others, while the last three (faith, meekness, and temperance) speak of my response to God. (Words as in KJV) Humility is knowing myself as I am. Nothing more and nothing less! “I am a leader in the church of Christ” may be said with pride, boastfully or with humility as Paul is doing here. False humility (“Oh, I’m nothing but a worm!”) is a sickness akin to pride.

Gentleness is elsewhere translated as ‘meekness’ – teachability or pliability. It has been described as ‘controlled strength’ – like the stallion with the bit in its mouth.

Long-suffering (patience) – endures to the end, patience with men.

Tolerance with love – bearing with one another. This ‘love’ is ‘agape’ – which seeks nothing but the highest good.

4:17-24: Walk, no longer as the Gentiles walk.

A contrast between the old nature and the new nature (‘Gentile’ and New Man). The old man walked in darkness, lacking understanding, ignorant, and excluded from the life of God because of his hardness of heart, given to sensuality and impurity with greediness. These are all in contrast to what is demanded by the truth you have found in Christ.

Paul uses three very strong words to depict the heathen mind.

“hardness of heart” – porosis – petrified rock – calloused to lose all feeling.

“abandoned to sensuality” – aselgeia – does not care how he appears to others in his sensuality.

“impurity with greediness” – pleonexia – accursed love of possessing – lust for that which one has no right to.

We are to “lay aside” the old self; We are to be renewed in the spirit of our mind; We are to “put on” the new self.

These are actions we are accountable for – it is a continual attitude. Consider here, Romans 12:1, 2.

5: 1-6: Walk in love just as Christ also loved you...

These verses show us the lifestyle of a lover.

It is the 'engagement' covenant between two. There is no room for impurity in thought or living.

We are betrothed to our bridegroom, Christ, and are not to play the harlot with the world, as Israel did, though betrothed to God. Our best example is Jesus. His sacrificial life was as a fragrant aroma rising to God – acceptable. His was a perfect obedience and a perfect love.

It has been said that chastity is the one new virtue that Christianity brought to the world. The ancient world regarded sexual immorality so lightly that it was no sin at all.

Paul gives us two warnings: i) We are not even allowed to talk about such things lightly.

ii) We must not be deceived by empty words – voices that speak lightly of such things as the Gnostics did.

5:8-14: Walk as children of light.

You were once children of darkness, but now the light has come to guide you and to shine in this darkened world. We are not to keep company with darkness but rather, to walk in the light (of our groom). We are to walk carefully, with discretion, knowing that we belong to another and not to the world.

Verse 14 would appear to be part of an ancient hymn – possibly used in baptism?

5:15-21: Walk as wise men, not as unwise.

Know what the will of God is; study the Word, spend time alone with Him to allow His Spirit to teach you. Further, do not be drunk with wine but be filled with the Spirit.

Verse 17-21 : show us what we should become as we walk these ways. We must be a “Spirit - filled” people.

The following three pieces of evidence of a Spirit-filled life: i) a praising spirit (v19) ii) a thankful spirit (v20) iii) a submitted spirit (v21).

Don’t tell me you are filled with the Spirit if you are not a worshipper, nor if you grumble about the church or others in the fellowship. You are called to be a servant of all – submitted to serve.

There are many today who claim to be “Spirit - filled”. I believe we can question the reality of one who claims to be ‘Spirit - filled’ if these three ‘evidences’ are missing – more evident are grumbling, politicking, and pride. This is why Paul puts chapter 13 between chapters 12, 14 in 1 Corinthians. The latter teaches much about the charismata, gifts of the Spirit, and their operation in the local church, but such manifestations are such as a ‘noisy gong or a clanging cymbal – nothing of value. Chapter 12 speaks of the excellence of love, which should be evident whenever the charismata are exercised.

“I’m not interested in your talk – I’m more concerned about your walk.”

Godly Relationships

Having challenged us to be filled with the Spirit and giving us the three evidences of being so filled, Paul now goes on to show how this affects our relationships with others.

(i) Husbands and wives; (ii) children and parents; (iii) employers and employees.

Chapter 5:22-33

show us what is expected of both husband and wife in a good marriage.

In v22, we too often put the emphasis on the word ‘submit’ (or ‘subject’) when that word is not found in the original! It is a carry-over from the previous verse where it applies to all of us – men and women. Both parties are called to submit in v 21, just as both are called to ‘love one another’ in the great command of Jesus the night He died. By the way, this word we translate ‘submit’ has the meaning of honour rather than obey . (See also v 33). I must confess that my chest swells just a little when other men tell me how their wives comment on how wonderful a husband I am - according to my wife! She doesn’t join in their negative gossip about their own husbands.

I believe the emphasis here should be on the phrase “to your own husband”. In Bible days, women had little or no rights – they were treated at chattel – the possession of their husbands who could do as they liked. It

would be easy for women, hearing the gospel message for the first time, hearing that they were precious to a loving God, to honour the young man preaching this good news in the market square. Paul reminds them that their first ‘honour’ is to their own husbands – not the preacher.

In v23, the man is the ‘head’ over the woman in the sense of her ‘covering’ or protection. It carries with it great responsibility before it can exercise any authority. He is responsible for the spiritual nurturing and testimony of his family. Many will stand before the Lord one day, hoping that He will commend them for all the work they have done for the kingdom; instead He will ask why they neglected the spiritual growth and nurture of their own family members, their #1 priority!

In the same way Jesus is our ‘covering’ and thereby, the ‘Saviour of the body’.

In v25, men are to love their own wives as Christ loved the church ... a love without conditions.

History has proven over and over that the happiest marriages are those in which there is mutual love and submission (honour). I believe that when a man loves his wife (as Christ loves His bride, the church) and when women honour their husbands above all other men, their marriage will grow in sweetness and Christlikeness – a “delicious circle” in contrast to the vicious circle so common in worldly marriages today.

Chapter 5:32 : A great mystery .

Let us develop this theme more: In chapter 1:9, we read of this mystery, revealed in v10, that at the end of time, all things will be drawn together in Christ. i.e., He will be over ALL things. Government, nature, organisations, etc., will be under His control. At this moment, man is free to do ‘his own thing’, but that will end when ALL things are put under His feet.

In chapter 3:9, Paul rejoices that he has been called to reveal this mystery to the intent that “all in heavenly places” (the external world of the spirit) might know the purposes of God revealed through His church.

As we consider the ‘end of time’ in the book of Revelation, we see the exalted Jesus upon the throne, accompanied by The BRIDE, formerly the church. It is God’s good purpose that she should be exalted with Him as joint heir of all God’s riches! This is what He has willed to do and what will be revealed to “all in heavenly places”. This is the mystery! (God’s secret now revealed).

This is why Paul writes here of a mystery in connection with his teaching on the bride and the relationship of a marriage.

In chapter 6, Paul continues with his examples of lives “filled with the Spirit” - how children and parents should interact, how employers and their employees should relate. A Christian home should be an example to all other homes around. Parents have a responsibility to pour love into their children. This does not only mean hugs, cuddles and kisses but also esteem, value, safety, goals, Godly character.

A Christian employer should run his business with grace and encouragement – his employees should be the happiest workers around. They, in turn, should do their work with diligence and be known as trustworthy, willing to go beyond what their employer expects of them. Both are called to show integrity in all their actions.

Let us go back to chapter 4:25-32, where Paul gives us four principles which should govern us in all our relationships: (I have had many occasions to use these in marriage counselling).

i) Do not tell lies – even half-truths are lies. Consider the cover-ups we do almost daily.

“What’s wrong?” “O, nothing!” when we are hurting inside. Always keep open communication between you and your wife/husband/children/

colleagues.

ii) Be current – do not let the sun set on your squabble. Deal with it today. It will produce a ‘root of bitterness’ otherwise (Heb 12:15).

iii) Attack the problem, not the other person . Speak only that which edifies. Remember, the battle is with the enemy, not fellow members of the Body.

iv) PROact, not REact! Look for ways to turn enmity into unity.

Consider: i) What are lies? – Speech, silence, actions, etc.

ii) What is the right kind of ‘anger’? Righteous anger that changes situations – e.g., Wilberforce and slavery.

iii) How do we “give the devil an opportunity”? He will sow distrust and turmoil.

iv) Why does Paul write here about stealing? A demand for honesty/integrity in action as well as in words.

v) What are some unwholesome words we might say?

Paul ends the chapter with a list of things which should go from life: a) bitterness – long-standing resentment.

b) wrath and anger – short-term (temper) and long-term anger.

c) clamour and slander – loud talking (raised voices) and insulting language.

d) malice – bitterness of spirit to another.

Instead, we are to be kind, as defined by tender-hearted, forgiving. Such a life would be impossible if it were not for the Holy Spirit, who makes us “more than conquerors” by His fullness (Rom 8:37).

Greater is He that is in you than he that is in the world – 1 John 4:4.

Stand Firm

When we have learned to be seated in heavenly places (2:6) and to walk in love and in the light (5:2, 8), we are called to be strong and to stand firm (6:10,11). The bride of Chapter 8 must become an overcomer if she is to wear the crown and reign with Jesus. As such, she is called to be a soldier.

We saw in the first part of chapter 6 that Paul continues the theme of the Spirit-filled life as it applies to the relationship between children and parents; workers and masters. One major thought here is concerning ‘fathers’ who “provoke their children to anger.” It could well be mothers but is most commonly fathers. It is interesting that many psychologists consider “anger” as the fruit of inward wounds – wounds of the soul produced by fathers (and mothers) who do not fill their love-tank child with love (hugs, kisses, identity, morals, self-esteem, security, goals, etc.). It is my sad reflection that such wounds of the soul are the most effective weapons Satan uses in defeating many believers.

An interesting study is to consider what it means to be an ‘overcomer’ and to see the rewards of such overcoming. Let us take ‘time out’ to consider 3 verses in 1 John that speak about overcoming. 1 John 2:12-14 .

Here John places all believers in one of three categories which he calls, little children, fathers and young men.

Little children are those whose sins have been forgiven for His name’s sake (v12) and they can call God ‘Father’ (13). This is true of all who have been born again by the Spirit. They may know nothing of theology or

church history but they can say two things: “My sins are forgiven and I can call Him ‘Father’.” Note that this has nothing to do with chronological age. I know many believers, well on in age, who have sadly never progressed beyond this stage – they have remained childish!

Fathers are those who have come to know Him who is from the beginning. This is not just a head knowledge but an intimacy as God has made Himself known to them. This is the goal of Paul’s prayer in Eph 1:17.

This is Christian maturity – knowing Him. Note that this is not chronological age either, nor is it gender based. Happily, I know many young men and women who have come to know God in a deep personal way – they are spiritual ‘fathers’.

There is only one way we may progress from those early days of being ‘little children’ to a place where God makes Himself known to us as we progress in maturity – it is by being “young men”.

Again, this is not a chronological age nor a gender term.

Young men are those who have overcome the evil one (v13); they are strong because the word of God abides in them (v14). To every weapon of Satan they have an answer in the Word of God.

They counteract his lies with Biblical truth. e.g., the enemy might gloat over your failure and say, “God doesn’t love you any more as you have disappointed Him!” This lie is counteracted by the truth that “nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ Jesus” (Rom 8:39).

Whenever we are tried by our circumstances, by Satan’s lies, by temptations from the world, God is watching to see how we react. He is on the sidelines cheering us on. As we overcome, He rejoices and reveals more of His character to us.

Now let us look at the overcomers of Rev 2, 3 – where John sees the glorified Christ and is instructed to write to the seven churches of Asia

Minor. To end each letter, Jesus speaks of rewards given to “those who overcome”.

Rev 2 : the overcomer shall eat of the tree of life (v7); shall not be hurt by the second death (v11); shall feed on hidden ‘manna’ and shall be given a white stone and a new name (v17); shall be given authority over nations and the morning star (v26-8).

Rev 3 : the overcomer shall be clothed in white and have his name confessed before the Father and angels (v5); will be made a pillar in the eternal temple and shall receive the three-fold mark of God (v12); shall sit down with Jesus on His throne – reign with Him (v21).

This is why the Lord allows believers to go through some hard tests with suffering and opposition, and why He often seems to stay out of the difficulty even when we cry to Him in prayer. He wants us to become overcomers in the difficulty rather than Him delivering us from it. He has given us the Holy Spirit to be our helper in the battle and has given us armour to wear. Greater is He that is in us than he that is in the world.

Further, we should become adept in the “word” to understand the tactics of the enemy, Satan. Paul was quick to forgive, so he wouldn’t give Satan an advantage ‘for we are not ignorant of his tactics’ (2 Cor 2:11). Earlier in Ephesians, he exhorted us not to ‘let the sun go down on our wrath lest we give the devil a foothold’ (4:27).

Again, the devil will fire his ‘flaming arrows’ (6:16) – lies we so easily allow into our minds and believe. Peter describes him as a ‘roaring lion’ seeking whom he may devour (1 Peter 5:8) – those roars that affect our emotions and frighten us into cowardice in the battle. Remember that the roar is all he can do, for he has lost his teeth and claws!! Jesus disarmed him at the cross – Colossians 2:15.

The battle truly is the Lord’s , but we are to be armed to overcome.

Now let us return to Ephesians chapter 6: V 11: Put on the full armour of God.

V12 – 13: Note where our focus should be in this battle – it is not other people, believers or otherwise. This is where our energies should be directed. We are, of course, to oppose the flesh (our old self nature) but even that is a battle of the spirit rather than a battle of the material. We must see the enemy beyond the personality.

‘Principalities’ are spiritual overseers of governments, nations, etc.

‘Powers’ are demonic ‘pirates’ who carry out the devil’s work in smaller areas.

‘Rulers of darkness’ influence those who influence others – politicians, educators, philosophers, etc.

‘Spiritual wickedness’ refers to overseers of religion, etc.

These are approximate divisions of the various ranks of angels (fallen) and were a common understanding in Paul’s day.

V14: Truth is the key garment to which all others are tied or joined. We desperately need truth or integrity in all our actions. The breastplate of righteousness guards our hearts; our feet are shod with the preparation of the gospel of peace – we are always on mission!

Note that there is no armour for the back! One cannot turn and run away!

V17, 18: The offensive weapons are a sword (the Word of God) and prayer in the Spirit. By these we shall be overcomers, so we had better learn how to use them! I am amazed at how many believers go into battle without being “prayed up”!

Finally, in 1 Thess 5:8, Paul adds to this armour, “Put on the breastplate of faith and love and for a helmet, the hope of salvation.” Again , we see Paul’s three jewels – he puts them together at least 7 times in his letters,

most notably in that great chapter on love – 1 Cor 13 13 – “Now, faith, hope, love abide these three, but the greatest of these is love” .

We so seldom recognise the greatness of (Christian) hope, associating it with its weak English meaning. “I hope it doesn’t rain today” , – but it might!

To Paul, hope was something far greater. Before King Agrippa, he would declare, “These Jews accuse me of insurrection, but I stand before you today for the hope of the resurrection!” (Acts 26:1-8 paraphrased). He is not saying, “I hope there’s a resurrection and that I have not given up my great career to follow this way!” He is saying, “I know that I know that I know there is a resurrection for me!” He has a certainty within him.

I define hope as “an attribute of the mind and is evidenced in confidence”. This is why the helmet is called the hope of salvation .

Similarly, “faith is an attribute of the heart and is evidenced in obedience.”

I trust these short chapters have been a blessing to you as you seek to draw close to Him - learning to be seated in Him and to walk in love and the light. May you be an overcomer to whom the Lord is happy to reveal more of His character.

Let me close with Paul’s prayer: (1:15 -20; 3:16-19) I pray that the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of Glory, may give to you a spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of Him. I pray that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened, so that you will know what is the hope of His calling, what are the riches of the glory of His inheritance in the saints, and what is the surpassing greatness of His power toward us who believe ... that He would grant to you, according to the riches of His glory, to be strengthened with power through His Spirit in the inner man, so that Christ may dwell in your hearts through faith, and that you, being rooted and grounded in love, may be able to comprehend with all the saints what is

the breadth and length and height and depth, and to know the love of Christ which surpasses knowledge, that you may be filled up to all the fullness of God.

To Him be glory in the church!!

THE END

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